
Substance Use

Sam Coffey, Emerson Ackerman, Halle Rigden
& Gabe Eze

AGENDA

1. **Health concern:** Vaping is a gateway drug that can lead to addiction and further health issues
2. **Health disparity:** Youth are increasingly susceptible to vaping
3. **Proposed solution:** An education intervention for parents, teachers, youth, and community leaders on how to identify the issue, how to quit, and why vaping is dangerous.
4. **Conclusion**

Main goal: Lower the rate of vaping in youth within the total service area (6 surrounding counties in Kentucky)

Vaping Has Serious Health Effects

- Dangerous heavy metals and carcinogens in the vapor (1)
- Impairment on memory and attention by affecting the developing brain (1)
- Increased risk for psychiatric disorders (3)
- Children are more likely to vape than adults (4)
 - Marketing
 - Social influence



Vaping is a gateway drug that can lead to addiction

- Vulnerability of the adolescent brain to developing addiction and more severe withdrawal symptoms (1)
- Youth vape users more likely to initiate alcohol use and possibly other substances (2)
- Some youth vape users also use e-cigarettes to smoke marijuana and other drugs (1)



Kentucky vs. U.S. Vaping Rates

- Vaping rates in Kentucky are higher in comparison to vaping rates across the US (5)
 - 46% Appalachian undergraduates report e-cigarette use
 - 15.2% of U.S. undergraduate report e-cigarette use

- E-cigarette use is higher in Kentucky, specifically Appalachia (6)
 - 18-24 year old Appalachians report current use of e-cigarettes (13.9%) and lifetime use (43.1%)
 - 18-24 U.S. report current use of e-cigarettes (10.3%) and lifetime use (41.7%)

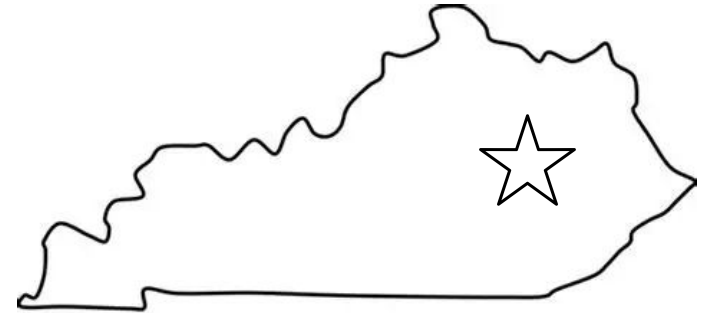
Vaping Rates in Kentucky, Compared to US

Characteristic	Appalachia (n = 3111)		Kentucky (n = 18 907)		Median weighted % (95% CI) United States (n = 896 543)	
	Current	Lifetime	Current	Lifetime	Current	Lifetime
	e-cigarette use	e-cigarette use	e-cigarette use	e-cigarette use	e-cigarette use	e-cigarette use
Overall	6.4 (4.8-8.0)	29.3 (26.5-32.0)	5.8 (5.2-6.4)	27.0 (25.9-28.0)	4.6 (4.0-5.1)	21.4 (19.4-23.5)
Age, y						
18-24	13.9 (6.3-21.5)	43.1 (33.9-52.3)	11.9 (9.0-14.9)	45.2 (41.2-49.0)	10.3 (8.9-11.3)	41.7 (38.5-44.6)
25-44	7.3 (4.8-9.8)	38.3 (32.9-43.8)	6.8 (5.7-7.9)	35.0 (32.8-37.1)	5.9 (5.2-6.8)	29.3 (26.1-31.4)
45-54	4.6 (2.5-6.6)	27.7 (21.7-33.7)	5.2 (4.1-6.4)	26.3 (23.9-28.7)	3.8 (2.9-4.6)	17.9 (15.6-20.1)
55-64	7.4 (3.6-11.2)	28.0 (22.1-33.9)	5.6 (4.0-7.2)	22.0 (19.8-24.3)	2.7 (2.1-3.5)	13.7 (12.1-16.1)
≥65	0.5 (0-0.9)	7.7 (4.9-10.4)	1.3 (0.8-1.8)	8.3 (7.1-9.4)	1.0 (0.7-1.2)	5.5 (4.9-6.7)

Christian, W. J., Valvi, N. R., & Walker, C. J. (2022). Examining Adult E-cigarette Use in Kentucky and Its Appalachian Region Using the Behavioral Risk Factor Surveillance System, 2016-2017. *Public Health Reports*®, 137(5), 878-887.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/00333549211029972>

Local: Rural Kentucky

- Comparing rates in the US with rates in Kentucky, evidence shows that Kentucky vaping rates are significantly higher (5)
- Appalachian, rural high school students are more likely to engage in e-cigarette use (7)
- Rural adolescent e-cigarette use continues to be an issue that need to be addressed (8)



Proposed Solution: Education Intervention

- Education interventions have been proven effective to stop and prevent vaping in youth (9,10,11)
- Plan:
 - Youth intervention: educate youth on dangers of vaping and provide resources to help them quit
 - Adult intervention: Partnering with Dr. Melinda Ickes #Icanendthetrend campaign from UK to develop teacher and resource officer intervention resources

EXAMPLE OF YOUTH INTERVENTION

WHY THIS MATTERS

► SUMMARY

Vaping is dangerous and not worth the many health risks. What you choose to do with vaping matters. Choosing to vape can have long lasting effect and it is simply not worth it.

BE STRONG ENOUGH TO SAY NO AND SMART ENOUGH TO MEAN IT

♥ CARE ABOUT YOUR HEALTH

Your health is not a joke. Understand how much vaping can hurt your body and choose to put yourself first.

**YOU GET ONE BODY
DON'T FILL IT WITH POISON**

🎯 GOALS

Understand the big problems with vaping and encourage your friends to quit. We want to end the vaping trend and it starts with you.

BE THE GENERATION THAT ENDS VAPING

CHOOSE **NOT** TO VAPE



THE DANGERS OF VAPING

IT'S JUST NOT WORTH IT



AN EDUCATIONAL GUIDE TO THE DANGERS OF VAPING AND STRATEGIES TO QUIT

DANGER

VAPING IS A GATEWAY DRUG

Even if vaping does not seem dangerous now it could lead to more dangerous drugs. Here are some facts you should consider before picking up that vape:

- Vape users are more likely to try more dangerous drugs
- The young brain is more likely vulnerable to develop addictions
- Of young people that do have addictions, negative symptoms from stopping occur earlier and more often

VAPING CAN CAUSE BIG HEALTH PROBLEMS

You may have heard that vapes are the "safer" than cigarettes, but that does NOT mean they are safe.

Here are some health effects you should consider before picking up that vape:

- Vaping can harm your memory and attention
- Inhaling the chemicals in vapes can hurt your lungs and brain
- Vaping can effect your brain development



RISK

COMPANIES TARGET YOUTH

There is a reason why companies make "fun" flavored and colored vapes. Companies aim marketing campaigns at the youth making them more susceptible to vaping. Do NOT be fooled by different celebs advertising vapes, they are HARMFUL.

EXPERIMENTING IS NOT WORTH IT

One of the main reasons youth say they started vaping was to experiment, just to try it out. **Your body is not a health experiment-think twice before picking up that vape.**

JUST SAY NO

Youth also said that peer influence is what led them to vaping. Trends may fade by that damage done to your body will stay forever. Be the reason your friend quit, not the reason they start.



STRATEGIES TO QUIT

MAKE A PLAN

- Pick a quite date
- Track your streak
- Reward yourself

REPLACE THE HABIT

- Exercise!
- Make a healthy swap- try gum or toothpicks
- Try new hobbies

TRAIN YOUR MIND

- Remind yourself why you want and need to quit
- Use positive self talk
- Reflect on the progress you have made



Intervention Analysis

- Distribution:
 - Youth
 - Teacher/Community Members
 - Parents
- Success:
 - Short-term: before and after surveys for effectiveness of intervention
 - Long-term: including community vaping rates in CHNA



Strengths and Limitations

Strengths:

- Reaches primary risk group: Early education build awareness and resistance skills
- Leveraging home influence by supporting better parent-youth communication and addressing underestimation of vaping prevalence
- Educators can spot early signs, reinforce anti-vaping norms, and integrate content into health or life-skills classes

Strengths and Limitations

Limitations:

- Short-term retention: Without ongoing reinforcement, knowledge and attitudes fade quickly
- Knowledge gaps: Parents may have misconceptions about vaping and addiction, need targeted coaching
- Time/resource limits: Health education is often undervalued and may receive limited time and engagement

Conclusion

- Higher local rates in Kentucky exceed national averages
- Strong influences (family, peers, and marketing) heavily drive vaping initiation
- Planned intervention to provide education for youth, teachers, parents, and public health leaders

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An evidence-informed, peer-led prevention service that empowers students to be leaders while providing prevention education to youth, families, and communities across Kentucky.

In partnership with



Kentucky Public Health

Prevent. Promote. Protect.

Harm Reduction



EDUCATE

Provide students, community members, and professionals with evidence-informed information on the risks of nicotine use.



ENGAGE

Work closely with youth through peer-led conversations and experiences that bolster connection and involvement.



EMPOWER

Help students recognize their strengths and realize their potential to lead change in their schools and communities.



INSPIRE

Ignite passion and purpose in students and communities to drive a movement toward healthier, nicotine-free lives.



ADVOCATE

Equip students with the knowledge and confidence to speak out against vaping and stand up for healthier schools & communities.

SCHOOL PRESENTATIONS



Delivered dynamic, engaging presentations led by college student facilitators, offering the knowledge and support to drive change while adapting based on student feedback.

YOUTH ADVISORY BOARD

A group of 10 high school students statewide, dedicated to advocating for tobacco prevention, leading impactful campaigns, and hosting key events like the Kentucky Youth Tobacco Control Workshop and Youth Advocacy Summits.



PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Provided professional development for educators, healthcare professionals, and public health specialists, equipping them with the tools to support tobacco prevention & reaching 250+ individuals.

SOCIAL MEDIA



Reached youth and community member through engaging posts and media across multiple social platforms.



An evidence-informed, peer-led prevention service that empowers students to be leaders while providing prevention education to youth, families, and communities across Kentucky.



E-cigarette and tobacco prevention



Youth empowerment and mental health skill building



Current trends & research



Dynamic based on student feedback



Peer-led, college students

SINCE 2019, OUR COLLEGE FACILITATORS HAVE REACHED...



30,000+ students



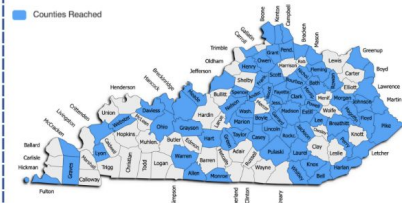
75 counties



150+ schools

THROUGH IN-SCHOOL PRESENTATIONS

Countries Reached



4 COHORTS OF THE YOUTH ADVISORY BOARD



2024 Campaign for Tobacco-Free Kids' Group Youth Advocate of the Year

Mobilized a statewide Youth Advisory Board of 39 high school students across 21 counties, who led two advocacy campaigns, engaged nearly 300 advocates at youth summits, & held 90+ lawmaker meetings.

PEERS (PREVENTION, EDUCATION, EMPOWERMENT, AND RESOURCES FOR STUDENTS) PROGRAM

Engaged over 20 high school and college students through the PEERS program to lead prevention efforts across 31 counties, partner with three universities, and deliver programming to more than 2,000 students through trained college facilitators.

RESEARCH & PRESENTATIONS

Conducted ongoing program evaluation and share findings through peer-reviewed publications and presentations at local, state, and national conferences—contributing to the broader public health field and advancing evidence-based tobacco prevention.



@ SOCIAL MEDIA INTERACTIONS

Maintained a growing digital presence with over 1,800 followers across social media, developed parent-focused PSAs on youth vaping, and engaged students creatively through an annual art challenge with 30+ submissions and 9 award winners.

This project was supported by funds made available by the Kentucky Department for Public Health through grant 3200006359. The findings of the project are those of the authors and do not necessarily represent the official position of or endorsement by the Kentucky Department for Public Health.



BOOK US! 



<https://bookicanendthetrend.timetap.com/#/>

What is #iCANendthetrend?

#iCANendthetrend is an evidence informed, peer-led prevention and empowerment program developed by University of Kentucky researchers and college students to help build awareness on the dangers of tobacco use, including e-cigarette use, and the costs associated with nicotine dependence.

How #iCANendthetrend Supports Tobacco Prevention Efforts

School Presentations

.....



Current trends and research



Youth empowerment



Align with National & Kentucky Education Standards



Updated by student feedback



Peer-led, college students

Professional Development

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We assist...



Public health professionals



School personnel



Community stakeholders



Parents

by sharing up-to-date information, resources, & youth perspective

Community Outreach

.....



Youth Advisory Board

- State-wide high school empowerment program



PEERS

- High school & undergraduate advocate training program



Social Media

@icanendthetrend    

Newsletter: <https://tinyurl.com/ICETTNL>

Contact: icanendthetrend@uky.edu

